

IT FOLDER

Weekly Investment News

20 to 26 July 2026

Concrete news, categorised for public and private-market research

What changed: This version captures the useful underlying news from the folder. Each item is organised as: what was reported, why it could matter, and a completed quick source-check. It is not a buy list or investment recommendation.

72 messages reviewed; promotional, operational and generic technology emails excluded

1. Public markets

Most useful signal: The strongest public-market thread is not “AI” in the abstract. It is the growing tension between AI demand and the cost of compute, power and financing - a useful screen for separating beneficiaries from balance-sheet risk.

AI financing and infrastructure: the cost side is moving into focus

Reported: PitchBook flagged AI cost and power-broker themes; separate coverage noted CoreWeave turning to the loan market and an ongoing AI bond-financing wave. PitchBook also covered Francisco Partners’ reported \$21 billion AI-related bet and debate around infrastructure oversupply.

Why it matters: This sharpens the distinction between companies monetising AI demand and those funding the capacity. Credit availability, power costs and contract structure can now change the equity case materially.

- **Quick follow-up finding:** CoreWeave’s May investor release confirms a \$3.1 billion loan facility designed to broaden financing for GPU-backed infrastructure; press reporting also described a later \$2.6 billion debt raise. The funding route is real, but it reinforces the key risk: leverage and counterparty-backed backlog must be tested alongside demand. Francisco Partners’ reported \$21 billion bet was not independently substantiated in this quick check.

Tokenised equities gain a US distribution route

Reported: Converge reported that Ondo’s broker-dealer had been cleared to sell tokenised equities to US investors, alongside record tokenised-stock activity. The Defiant separately reported Uniswap v4 opening to regulated assets.

Why it matters: If verified, this is market-structure progress rather than a pure crypto-price signal. It raises the relevance of regulated brokerage, custody, transfer, compliance and distribution economics.

- **Quick follow-up finding:** Verified: Ondo said its SEC-registered broker-dealer, Oasis Pro Markets, received SEC/FINRA authorisations on 23 July. Broadridge and Ondo had already launched custodial tokenised U.S. securities in production, including BlackRock IVV and Micron. Broadridge is a named listed infrastructure participant; neither release discloses live volumes or material revenue.

TRON: stablecoin scale and fee generation

Reported: CoinDesk research reported USDT on TRON at a reported \$89 billion all-time high, \$89 million of protocol fees, and TRX outperforming Bitcoin during the period.

Why it matters: The useful issue is whether stablecoin settlement activity is producing durable network, exchange, payments or infrastructure economics - not the token price alone.

- **Quick follow-up finding:** CoinDesk Research corroborates the scale: Q2 USDT market cap on TRON was just over \$89 billion and Q2 fees were about \$89 million. TRON DAO separately reported USDT supply above \$90 billion in July. The activity is verified at a network level, but no direct listed-company revenue beneficiary has been established.

China technology and autos: two near-term research catalysts

Reported: CLSA scheduled a China Technology discussion on PCBs and GPUs and a 29 July China Autos call on accelerating flash-charging deliveries.

Why it matters: These are not investable facts by themselves, but they point to where company-level demand, capacity and margin data may be arriving: AI hardware supply chains and EV charging ecosystems.

- **Quick follow-up finding:** The folder invitations did not contain the underlying company list or KPI data, so this remains a catalyst watch rather than a completed screen. No company-level order, utilisation or margin evidence was found in the quick check; retain only after the CLSA materials identify the relevant names.

Lower-priority public-market prompt

- **Copart:** The quick check attributes the fall to a CEO transition, competitive fee-rate pressure and a fiscal-Q2 miss. These are plausible drivers, but no official earnings release, current valuation or volume/price data was gathered here. It remains a watch item, not an investment conclusion.

2. Private markets

Most useful signal: Funding is concentrating in cross-border financial infrastructure, dollar-access rails, embedded finance and products that allow AI agents to transact. That gives a more specific sourcing agenda than a generic “fintech” or “AI” bucket.

Ant International: \$1.2 billion Series A for cross-border payments and agentic commerce

Reported: This Week in Fintech reported that Singapore-based Ant International raised approximately \$1.2 billion in Series A financing to expand cross-border payments and agentic-commerce products.

Why it matters: The size and use of proceeds make it a major validation point for international payment rails and AI-enabled commerce. It is also a competitor and valuation reference for regional infrastructure assets.

- **Quick follow-up finding:** The \$1.2 billion financing was corroborated by industry reporting, but this quick check did not locate issuer-published terms, a valuation, product revenue mix or an investor list. Treat the round size as a validated market signal, while the underwriting inputs remain unverified.

Augustus: \$180 million Series B at a \$1 billion valuation

Reported: Stablecon and This Week in Fintech reported that global clearing bank Augustus raised \$180 million to provide international banks and fintechs with direct access to US-dollar accounts and payment rails.

Why it matters: This is a concrete lead in “global dollar infrastructure”: an investable category spanning correspondent access, treasury, settlement, compliance and liquidity.

- **Quick follow-up finding:** Verified from Augustus's 21 July release: \$180 million Series B at a \$1 billion valuation. Reporting also named Tiger Global as lead. The company's releases do not substantiate customer concentration, unit economics, licenses or partner economics, so those remain diligence gates rather than assumptions.

Financial-infrastructure rounds: Lumin, Parafin and BusinessNext

Reported: The folder reported Lumin Digital raising more than \$115 million at a \$1.6 billion valuation; Parafin securing a \$300 million forward-flow agreement for SMB loans; and BusinessNext raising \$40 million from ServiceNow at a \$700 million valuation.

Why it matters: Together these point to demand for financial-institution software, embedded lending and autonomous-banking tooling - but with very different capital and credit risk profiles.

- **Quick follow-up finding:** Lumin confirmed on its site that \$70 million of new client investment followed a prior \$45 million financing, taking fresh capital above \$115 million at a \$1.6 billion valuation. ServiceNow confirmed its \$40 million BusinessNext investment; BusinessNext cites 75,000+ deployed branches/contact centres/touchpoints, but that is an issuer claim. Parafin's \$300 million forward-flow item was not independently confirmed in this quick review. Keep it as unverified until the counterparty or Parafin discloses terms.

Agentic payments and stablecoin settlement: Natural and Cyclops

Reported: This Week in Fintech reported Natural raising \$30 million to build technology allowing AI agents to hold, receive and move money autonomously, while Cyclops raised \$20 million for crypto acceptance and stablecoin settlement infrastructure.

Why it matters: These are early but specific signals for a new stack: agent identity, permissions, wallet controls, settlement and fraud prevention.

- **Quick follow-up finding:** Natural confirmed a \$30 million Series A led by Forerunner; independent coverage also described \$40 million total funding. Cyclops confirmed a \$20 million Series A led by Nava Ventures. Both rounds are verified, but neither source discloses revenue, transaction volumes or the required operating permissions; commercial proof is still absent.

3. Regulation, financing risk and catalysts

Most useful signal: Financial infrastructure and digital assets are becoming more investable only where operating permission, AML/CFT controls and payment-system resilience can be demonstrated. Regulatory evidence needs to sit beside product and growth evidence.

Hong Kong: virtual-asset AML/CFT circular

Reported: The SFC issued a circular to licensed corporations, SFC-licensed virtual-asset service providers and associated entities covering anti-money-laundering and counter-financing-of-terrorism requirements.

Why it matters: This is directly relevant to Hong Kong-facing virtual-asset, custody, brokerage and compliance businesses. Regulation is not background context; it can determine addressable market and operating cost.

- **Quick follow-up finding:** Verified from the SFC distribution: circular 26EC46 concerns the United Nations Sanctions (Libya) Regulation 2019 and applies to licensed corporations, SFC-licensed VASPs and associated entities. It is a sanctions-screening and compliance update, not a new comprehensive AML/CFT regime. Use it as a diligence control check, not a market-structure catalyst.

Hong Kong securities-market infrastructure: HKEX backbone-network tests

Reported: The SFC circulated updates on HKEX post-release tests for the launch of a backbone-network upgrade for securities-market systems.

Why it matters: The item is a reminder to monitor market-infrastructure upgrades where vendors, brokers, custodians or data providers may face implementation cost or demand.

- **Quick follow-up finding:** Verified from SFC notices: the second market rehearsal had been completed and a third-quarter 2026 network upgrade was planned. The notices identify a market-operational milestone, but no named technology or procurement beneficiary was disclosed. The useful near-term tracker date is Q3, not a stock-specific catalyst.

US market structure: SEC e-delivery proposal

Reported: Sidley reported an SEC proposal that would make paper delivery the exception under Regulation E-Delivery.

Why it matters: Digitisation of investor communications can alter compliance workflows, document-delivery costs and demand for secure distribution and recordkeeping technology.

- **Quick follow-up finding:** Verified from the SEC's 16 July proposal: electronic delivery could be used without affirmative consent subject to conditions, with paper opt-out and transition protections. The public comment period is 60 days after Federal Register publication. This is proposed, not final; no immediate compliance winner should be assumed.

Crypto policy: progress, but policy risk remains binary

Reported: The folder carried reports on US CLARITY-related vote odds and ethics issues, plus digital-asset regulatory developments including a Brazilian tokenisation task force and Bank of Korea preparations for live CBDC transactions.

Why it matters: These are meaningful market-structure markers, but the investment implication depends on enacted rules, scope and implementation - not newsletter commentary.

- **Quick follow-up finding:** Brazil's CVM confirmed a 17 July tokenisation working group covering registration, custody, trading and settlement, with an initial experimental proposal due within 60 days. The Bank of Korea CBDC point could not be confirmed from a primary source in this quick check. Record Brazil as verified and Korea as report-only until an official notice appears.

Credit and operating-risk items to carry forward

- **Private-credit stress - quick finding:** The CoreWeave financing check above provides direct evidence that AI infrastructure is drawing large, structured debt facilities. It supports making refinancing, lender concentration, contract

enforceability and downside liquidity mandatory underwriting items; it does not by itself establish broad BDC stress.

- **Security and fraud - quick finding:** AFX Trade's bridge was reported by Blockaid and The Block as losing roughly \$24.15 million in USDC, while Arbitrum's native bridge was explicitly not implicated. The incident validates bridge-specific security as a gating diligence issue. The MetaMask allegation and scam trend were not independently verified here.
- **Asia regulatory cost - quick finding:** A 14 July Digital Prosperity Asia study supports the broader point that Malaysian data, cybersecurity and higher-risk AI rules can affect startup operations and investment decisions. It is policy research rather than an enacted-cost schedule; quantify the burden only after mapping a target's data, critical-infrastructure and cross-border-transfer exposure.

4. Additional quick checks

- **Fintech licensing:** Nubank confirmed a Brazilian banking-licence path through its acquisition of Banco Porto Real. Upstart confirmed conditional OCC approval to establish Upstart Bank, subject to further approvals and build-out. These are verified operating-permission milestones, but conditional approval is not a fully functioning bank and neither item establishes economics.
- **Regional stablecoin distribution:** Samsung Wallet stablecoin support was reported in trade press, but no confirming Samsung newsroom announcement was located in this quick check. SCRYPT's expansion into four East African corridors was confirmed through its own release; its compliance and scale claims remain company assertions. Both are distribution-watch items rather than verified volume signals.
- **SEA deal flow:** SBI's planned acquisition/capital injection into Singapore's Coinhako is confirmed as subject to regulatory approvals, but the retrieved sources did not disclose final terms or demonstrate completion. The Kindred, pQCee and Vertical Ocean references were not independently verified; do not use them as transaction comparables yet.
- **Energy storage:** The European Commission confirms that the battery-passport registry became operational on 20 July 2026 and that passports become mandatory for relevant battery categories from 18 February 2027. This validates regulation as a market-access and data-infrastructure catalyst; the oil-major registration claim from the folder was not independently confirmed.

How to use the quick checks

- **Verified:** an official regulator or company source was located, though company-issued operational claims should not be treated as independently audited.
- **Reported / unverified:** the folder item was not corroborated in the allotted quick review, or source terms were incomplete. It should not be used as an underwriting fact.
- **Important limitation:** a quick check can validate an event or regulatory status; it does not establish valuation, unit economics, security quality or investment suitability.

Source note: Folder news was drawn from investment-relevant messages received in the Outlook IT folder from 20-26 July 2026. Quick checks used primary sources where available, including SEC, SFC, CVM Brazil, European Commission, company investor/newsroom releases, Ondo/Oasis Pro, Broadridge, CoreWeave, Lumin, Augustus, Natural, Cyclops, ServiceNow and SBI. Unverified labels mean a primary confirmation was not located in the allotted quick review. This is research support, not investment advice.